

The essay began by noting that the profit motive is hardly the only motive that lies behind the labors of American business leaders. Other motives include “the love of power or prestige, altruism, pugnacity, patriotism, the hope of being remembered through a product or institution.” Even as I freely confess to all of these motives—life is too short to be a hypocrite—I also agree with *Fortune* on the appropriateness of the traditional tendency of American society to ask: “What are the moral credentials for the social power that the businessman wields?”

The *Fortune* article quotes the words of Quaker businessman John Woolman of New Jersey, who in 1770 wrote that it is “good to advise people to take such things as were most useful, and not costly,” and then cites (almost inevitably) Benjamin Franklin’s favorite words, industry and frugality, as “the means of producing wealth and receiving virtue.”

Moving to 1844, the essay cites William Parsons, “a merchant of probity,” who described the good merchant as “an enterprising man willing to run some risks, yet not willing to risk in hazardous enterprises the property of others entrusted to his keeping, careful to indulge no extravagance and to be simple in his manner and unostentatious in his habits, not merely a merchant, but a man, with a *mind* to improve, a *heart* to cultivate, and a *character* to form.”

A Merchant and a Man

I found Parsons’ definition of *merchant* and *man*, set out more than 160 years ago, to be more than inspiring; it seemed aimed directly at me. The words about the prudence, trustworthiness, and simplicity of the enterprising man struck me as apt descriptions of the goals of my own career and my life. And the three qualities that defined the merchant as a man were, I think, equally appropriate. As for the mind, I still strive every day—I really do!—to improve my own mind, reading, reflecting, and challenging even my own deep-seated beliefs, and writing about the issues of the day with passion and conviction.